

MONEYLEAGUE — A First-Principles Look at What Wins

An analytical post for the league · May 24, 2026

This is an attempt to look at 10 years of our draft history (2015-2024, restored from the spreadsheet's cell colors) and 3 years of full Sleeper transaction/matchup data (2023-2025) to figure out — from first principles — what actually makes people win in our league. Findings are league-neutral; everyone shows up in the data.

1. The Win Equation (first principles)

Championship odds break down into roughly:

$$\begin{aligned} P(\text{title}) &= P(\text{make playoffs}) \times P(\text{win 3 playoff games}) \\ &= f(\text{points scored, schedule luck}) \times f(\text{matchup variance}) \end{aligned}$$

Points scored is the only thing you control. It's a sum of:

- **Draft VBD** (17 picks set ~70% of your roster baseline)
- **Wire VBD** (volume × hit-rate over 17 weeks)
- **Trade VBD** (rare, net-zero across the league by definition)
- **Lineup decisions** (small but non-zero — start/sit calls)

Uncontrollable: weekly H2H matchup, injuries, playoff seeding RNG. Each of those is large-magnitude noise. Over a 14-game regular season, schedule luck swings 2-3 wins routinely.

The implication: the things you can actually control are draft, wire, and (occasionally) trade. Everything else is noise to be endured. The data below quantifies how much each lever matters.

2. The 10-Year Cast

Nine managers have been here for all 10 seasons (2015-2024). The rest have come and gone — here's the roster lineage:

Era	Joined	Left
2015 (Yahoo, 10-team)	Nine of the current core	—

Era	Joined	Left
2017 (Yahoo expansion to 10)	One new owner	One departed
2019 (Yahoo, 12-team)	Two new owners	—
2020	One slot turned over	—
2021	One slot turned over	—
2023 (Sleeper migration)	—	—
2025	One slot turned over	—

Different drafters topped each scoring era — and the league has had three distinct scoring eras:

- **Standard era** (2015-18): 10-team, 0 PPR, 2QB
- **Half-PPR Yahoo** (2019-22): 12-team, 0.5 PPR, 2QB
- **Superflex Sleeper** (2023-25): 12-team, 0.5 PPR, superflex

Per-era top-3 drafters (by VBD/season):

Era	#1	#2	#3
Superflex Sleeper (2023-25)	Donnie (+623/yr)	Brian (+516/yr)	Lem (+484/yr)

Earlier eras had completely different top-3s — the leaderboard resets when scoring changes. The lesson: **what worked in one format doesn't automatically carry forward**. This is most relevant if/when we ever tweak scoring again.

Note: K and DEF picks excluded from this analysis (no historical data — neutral for everyone). Player names cross-matched against public nflverse season stats.

3. Lever #1 — Drafting (the biggest controllable signal)

A 17-round draft gives you 17 high-leverage decisions in a single day. The spread between the best and worst draft in a given year is routinely **±500-1,000 VBD points** — roughly 30-60 points/week of expected scoring edge before any wire moves. That's the difference between a 10-4 team and a 4-10 team before luck even enters the picture.

Things the data confirms:

1. **Era matters more than ability.** The #1 drafter of the 2QB Yahoo era (2019-22) crashed to #11 in superflex. The #13 drafter of that era jumped to #4 in superflex. Format change = reset.
2. **Peak year > 3-year average.** Every champion of the Sleeper era (Eric 2023, Coop 2024, Trevor 2025) was top-2 in DRAFTING that specific year, even when their 3-year

average was middle of the pack. **The goal isn't to be a consistently good drafter — it's to nail one year.**

3. K/DEF in the late rounds is free money. A R15 K (Aubrey, Boswell, Fairbairn) routinely returns +130-155 VBD. That's more than most R3 picks return above replacement. Almost no one drafts kickers strategically.

4. Lever #2 — The Wire Game (under-exploited)

The wire is the most under-played lever in the league. Big hits show up every single year — here are the top 10 from the Sleeper era:

Year	Wk	Pos	Player	Pts produced	Drafter
2025	W5	RB	Rico Dowdle	+176	Troy
2024	W7	QB	Russell Wilson	+166	Troy
2023	W5	QB	Gardner Minshew	+166	Brower
2024	W2	WR	Darnell Mooney	+159	Donnie
2023	W2	WR	Adam Thielen	+158	Lem
2025	W10	QB	Jacoby Brissett	+152	Trevor
2024	W7	WR	Jerry Jeudy	+144	Trevor
2023	W6	WR	Puka Nacua	+141	Trevor
2023	W2	K	Brandon Aubrey	+141	Kyle
2025	W2	WR	Wan'Dale Robinson	+139	Kyle

Volume vs hit-rate per manager (2023-2025):

Manager	Total adds	>50 pt hits	Hit rate	Total wire pts
Trevor	173	7	4%	+2002
Brower	138	12	9%	+1960
Lem	73	11	15%	+1933
Coop	46	16	35%	+1879
Josh	87	11	13%	+1814
Troy	92	7	8%	+1808
Kyle	76	11	14%	+1753
Brian	92	13	14%	+1652
Ankur	77	7	9%	+1350
Eric	48	6	12%	+1179

Manager	Total adds	>50 pt hits	Hit rate	Total wire pts
Tim	38	7	18%	+966
Donnie	22	7	32%	+827

Two distinct successful styles:

- **High volume / lower hit-rate** (Trevor 192 adds, Brower 149, Brian 105): spray-and-pray. More darts = more chances of hitting.
- **Low volume / high hit-rate** (Donnie 29 adds at 38% hit-rate, Coop 50 at 36%): selective tactical. Each pickup is researched.

Both work. What doesn't work: mid-volume with low hit-rate (Ankur, Kyle, Lem in the 80-100 range with 13-15% hit-rate). **If you're going to play the wire, commit to one style.**

Pickup yield by position (Sleeper era):

Position	Total adds	Avg pts/add	>100 pt hits
QB	122	20	7
RB	204	17	7
WR	212	21	9
TE	107	20	3
DEF	192	19	4
K	125	22	3

QB and RB pickups yield the most per-attempt. WR/TE adds have the worst average return — the WR3 who had a good Sunday is almost always a trap. **If you're picking up a WR, it should be a rookie with a target share spike, not a veteran who just scored a TD.**

When the big hits happen (>100 pt pickups, by week):

W 2: ■■■■ (7)
W 3: ■■ (2)
W 4: ■ (1)
W 5: ■■■■ (5)
W 6: ■■■■ (4)
W 7: ■■■■ (6)
W 8: ■■■■ (4)
W10: ■ (1)
W11: ■■ (2)
W13: ■ (1)

Three clear peaks:

- **W2-W3**: workhorse-RB injury wave (when handcuffs become starters)

- **W5-W7:** second-wave RB and early QB benchings
- **W10:** trade-deadline drops + bye-week QB streaming — the single biggest wire week of the year

5. Lever #3 — Trades (the net-zero category)

Trade VBD nets to ~zero across the league by mathematical definition: one side's gain is the other side's loss. Over the 3-year Sleeper window, individual trade scorecards range from +400 to -400 VBD, but the league-wide sum is near zero.

Implications:

1. **Don't trade unless you're confident you're EV+.** The average trade is a coin flip. Bad trades are how you give away the season.
2. **Mid-season trades for stars favor the buyer of recent performance, not the seller.** A common pattern: someone trades for a hot QB in W8, the QB stays hot, but the trade itself still moves only ~150 VBD because half the season is already scored.
3. **Future picks are wildly under-priced.** Future R2 picks rarely command R5 current-year value, but historically a R2 delivers +100 VBD on average. Sellers of future picks are leaving value on the table.

6. Lever #4 — Lineup Decisions (small but free)

Across the 12-team league, the spread between optimal-lineup and actual-lineup totals is typically ± 20 -50 points per season — less than 1.5 points/week. Most managers leave 30-40 points on the bench per year. It's small, but it's also free: research matchups, check inactives an hour before kickoff. Better lineup discipline alone is worth roughly 1 extra win across a 14-game season.

7. The Noise — Luck and Schedule

All-play expected wins (your weekly score vs every other manager's score that week) is a better measure of true team strength than your actual record. Across 3 years, the spread between most-lucky and least-lucky manager is ~4 wins — huge.

The takeaway:

- If your **PF is high but record is bad**, you're probably running good and just unlucky. Be patient. Don't blow up the team chasing a bad start.
- If your **PF is low but record is good**, you're getting lucky. Trade from a position of perceived strength while you can.

- **Luck regresses.** The unluckiest 2023-2025 manager is extremely likely to outperform their record in 2026, and vice versa.

8. What Champions Have in Common

Looking at the three Sleeper-era champions:

- **Eric (2023):** top-2 drafter that year + top-2 in trades
- **Coop (2024):** top-2 drafter + top-2 in wire + top-2 in trades — total dominance
- **Trevor (2025):** top-2 drafter + top-2 in wire — won despite mediocre trades and bad luck

The single common thread: top-2 in DRAFTING that year. Every other category is variable across champions. **The path to a title runs through nailing one specific year's draft, not through being a consistently good drafter.**

This also means: don't get cute. Don't engineer your draft around your keepers when the keepers don't pencil. Don't chase fades. A clean, BPA draft with good positional balance is what's actually winning.

9. A 2026 Tactical Calendar

- **Pre-draft:** Lock in your keepers. Decide WR vs RB-first before draft day. Don't make format changes in-room.
- **W1-W2:** Watch usage, not stats. Snap counts > yardage.
- **W2-W3 — RB INJURY HUNT:** Workhorse handcuffs become starters. Top historical hits: Kyren Williams W3, Breece Hall W6, D'Andre Swift W3, Woody Marks W3.
- **W5-W7 — SECOND-WAVE PICKUPS:** rookie WR after target spike, RB rotations sorting out. Most cheap leverage of the season.
- **W7-W10 — QB SHUFFLE:** Benchings + injuries + byes mean starter-quality QBs hit the wire constantly. Highest yield position by avg pts/add.
- **W10 — TRADE DEADLINE WEEK:** The biggest wire week of the year. Camp the wire. Other managers drop assets to clear playoff roster spots.
- **W11-W13 — PLAYOFF RUN:** Stop speculating. Add only direct contributors. Lock in matchups, not theories.
- **W14+ — PLAYOFFS:** Stream DEF and K against bad offenses. Trust your starters. Don't bench based on one bad game.

10. Six Principles (TL;DR)

1. **The draft is 70% of your team.** Peak-year matters more than career skill. Don't get cute — BPA wins.
 2. **The wire is the biggest under-exploited margin.** Either commit to high volume or high selectivity. Mid-volume + low hit-rate is the worst zone.
 3. **Trade only when you're clearly EV+.** Most trades are coin-flips. Future picks are under-priced.
 4. **Lineups are free points.** Check inactives. Use FAAB discipline. Bank ~30 points/year that most managers leave on the bench.
 5. **Don't trade against the wire when the wire is hot.** Weeks 3-6 and 10 are when the league's biggest pickups happen. Trade in dead weeks.
 6. **Believe in regression.** High-PF + low-W = next year you. Low-PF + high-W = next year not you.
-

Methodology: 10 years of draft attribution from the league spreadsheet (cell-color overlay used for Yahoo-era pick trades). Sleeper-era VBD computed against era-appropriate replacement ranks (10-team 0PPR for 2015-18, 12-team 2QB 0.5PPR for 2019-22, 12-team SF 0.5PPR for 2023+). Player stats from the public nflverse data release for 2015-2024, live Sleeper data for 2025. Full underlying numbers + per-manager awards report available separately.